motifs that give the exhibition its name. Serpents, or nāgas, snake deities, are ubiquitous: often glimpsed entwined together and raising their hooded heads behind stupas, protecting the relics within. (According to various hagiographies, the serpent king Mucalinda once protected the Buddha as he meditated amid a storm, raising him above the floodwaters and spreading his seven-hooded head to shelter him from the rain.) The equally omnipresent trees, too, are closely associated with the life of the Buddha, with different species evoking his birth, his renunciation, his spiritual awakening, his first sermon, and his death. But both motifs—and their associated personified nature spirits, *nāgas*, *yaksas*, and *yaksīs*—appear throughout. Two of the earliest monastic complexes of the south—Dhulikatta and Amravati—had buxom lotus-proffering *yaksīs*, female nature spirits adorning their *āyāka* platforms and pillars.

Portly male nature spirits, *yaksas*, considered protectors of the earth's riches, can be seen romping across other sites in the Deccan, including one in Andhra Pradesh's Nagarjunakonda, where one appears with coins cascading from his headdress onto his hand. Through such figures, Buddhism, in its early days of expansion, aimed to absorb the powerful animistic nature cults that then dominated the religious landscape of ancient India. ■

Shruti Ravindran

Tree & Serpent: Early Buddhist Art in India 200 BCE – 400 CE *is on view at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York through November 13*

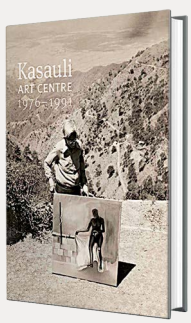
BOOKS

ART HOUSE

BELINDER DHANOA'S *KASAULI ART CENTRE 1976-1991* OUTLINES THE PIVOTAL ROLE THAT IVY LODGE, KASAULI, PLAYED IN THE WORLD OF INDIAN ART IN ITS HEYDAY

HUPEN KHAKHAR STANDS under the sun holding a canvas out in the open with the hills rising behind him. There is something revelatory about Khakhar's 1980 photograph—and many other such images of artists with paintings and sculptures outdoors, their families in tow, sharing plates of food, dancing and drinking into the night—that undoes the idea of what an institution can look like, what forms thinking and theorising can take. The texture of activities that were organised at Ivy Lodge—a mansion in Kasauli that artists Vivan and Navina Sundaram inherited from their mother, Indira Sher-Gil, in 1975—are the subject of Belinder Dhanoa's *Kasauli Art Centre 1976-1991*. The house is the book's protagonist. The way it was repurposed from being a home to a space for residencies with rooms for studios and more stately halls for discussion and dining, and the vistas it opened out to, all shaped the interactions between the participants. There, they could live and work together, and through that proximity exchange ideas and debate, which changed the course of each of their practices.

Dhanoa has constructed the book largely using long interviews with instrumental members. Among the artists and critics, Geeta Kapur, Nilima Sheikh and Gulammohammed Sheikh recount how the figure rooted in its context that came to be a defining feature of painting in Baroda and Bombay was imagined in part in the expansive discussions in Kasauli. Those working in theatre, like Anuradha Kapur, remember that the environs of Ivy Lodge lent an 'atmosphere' to their work with the audience looking down at actors from steps cut into the hillside and the valley and the sky forming an ever-changing backdrop. Recollections of pivotal presentations and seminars reveal the camaraderie behind the gatherings and how much each of these occasions benefited from interdisciplinary interactions.



KASAULI ART CENTRE 1976-1991
by Belinder Dhanoa
TULIKA BOOKS
₹3,000; 440 pages

While interviews drive the narrative, the book also includes pauses in the form of questions Dhanoa asks herself about her methodologies of research and writing, which reveal more about the process of writing a history of an institution in general than about the Kasauli Art Centre in particular. Other kinds of texts also intersperse the book such as scripts of films Navina Sundaram made on artists' camps for German television, letters from various participants detailing their ideas, archival catalogues of exhibitions that emerged from discussions at Ivy Lodge, and a timeline of events prepared by its driving force Vivan Sundaram, who passed away in March this year. The assembly of this information is particularly valuable to scholars seeking to understand progressive movements in art, theatre and cinema in the late 1970s and '80s.

Shared preoccupations of that time recur in all the conversations, particularly an interest in defining the role of art and the artist amidst upheavals like the Vietnam War, the Emergency and the rise of Hindutva. There is a sense that despite their staunch disagreements, everyone involved leaned towards the Left and believed in a secular nation-state. While reading about the various ways in which the Kasauli Art Centre nourished artists and birthed movements, one not only mourns the absence of such an institution today, but also realises how far we are from its ethos with certain artists who once occupied Ivy Lodge now participating in the recent Jana Shakti exhibition at NGMA Delhi celebrating the prime minister's *Mann Ki Baat* radio broadcasts. In that, the Kasauli Art Centre appears like an artefact of its time with no heir in the present. ■

Zeenat Nagree